

Morning Edition

Sunday, 2 August 2026

Ten stories on ocean governance, hydrospatial science, and SIDS equity, read through the lens of Francesca Adrienne's work at SHORE Institute and Shorelines.

JUMP TO

01 30×30 grant closes tomorrow ⚡

02 BBNJ's paperwork problem

⚡ DEADLINE: TOMORROW, 3 AUGUST

A \$15,000 door closes tomorrow

SHORE Institute runs on exactly this kind of grant: small enough that the big funders don't bother, large enough to cover a real season of fieldwork. The Sustainable Ocean Alliance's 30×30

fund is built for organisations Francesca's size, not the multilateral machinery she spends most of her week navigating.

SOA is taking proposals from small organisations and local leaders working on marine protected areas and other effective area-based conservation measures. Up to USD 15,000 per organisation, USD 5,000 for unaffiliated applicants, total pool USD 50,000 to 80,000, rolling review with notification in four to six weeks. The window closes 3 August 2026.

soalliance.org/stories/2026CFP

02

The high seas treaty's paperwork problem

Every marine protected area nomination that the Ocean Mapping Hub's work will eventually feed into runs through BBNJ's subsidiary bodies. Those bodies still don't formally exist, and the gap is no longer a technicality.

PrepCom3 concluded 2 April at UN Headquarters with real progress on the secretariat's structure and financial rules, but no agreement on how to nominate and elect members of the subsidiary bodies. That means those bodies won't be fully seated when COP1 opens on 11 January 2027, which risks pushing the first ABNJ protection proposals back by up to a year.

highseasalliance.org – PrepCom3: Inside the Negotiations

⚡ APPLICATIONS OPEN NOW

No. 03

Seychelles already has a seat reserved

The Commonwealth is holding a grant open specifically for the 25 Commonwealth SIDS, Seychelles among them. That's not a call Francesca has to compete globally for. It's a call her government is already eligible to fill, and one she could help shape or support through TICA or a partner ministry.

The COP29 Presidency–Commonwealth Fund for Small Island Developing States is disbursing US\$5 million over five years, with grants of up to US\$200,000 per country for one government-backed project each. Priorities are climate mitigation and

adaptation, restoration and conservation, a just energy transition, and ocean health.

thecommonwealth.org – COP29 Presidency-Commonwealth Fund for [SIDS](#)



\$ geoai --status marine_pipelines

This is the tooling layer underneath HARMONiSE: the automated pipelines that turn multibeam and satellite-derived bathymetry into usable coastal maps for governments that can't afford a full GIS unit. When this tech moves from paper to production, it changes what SHORE can credibly promise a client.

GeoAI workflows are now validated for coral reef segmentation on orthomosaics, detection of illegal, unreported, and unregulated fishing vessels from satellite radar, and automated habitat classification. The shift worth tracking is not the models themselves but their move from research papers into operational marine spatial

planning tools that non-specialist agencies can actually run.

05

Whose seabed data is it, really

This is the data sovereignty half of the High-Income SIDS Paradox: the gap between having ocean and having the capacity to govern data about it. Two developments this year sharpen the argument that capacity building has to include who owns and controls the data, not just who collects it.

The International Seabed Authority is running capacity-building programmes for Pacific SIDS on deep-seabed regulatory engagement, environmental management, and data governance, aimed at getting island states into the room for decisions currently made without them. Separately, the UN's Third World Ocean Assessment now formally calls for greater recognition of Indigenous knowledge within ocean governance frameworks, a shift Francesca has been arguing for from the Seychelles side of the table.

Sources: pina.com.fj, "Why Capacity Building Matters" (23 June 2026); Honolulu Star-Advertiser, "U.N. report highlights Indigenous knowledge in ocean governance" (29 July 2026)

pina.com.fj – [Capacity Building for Pacific SIDS](#)

06

SHARE OF THE OCEAN FLOOR NOW MAPPED

28.7%

Seabed 2030 just published its yearly report card

Seabed 2030 is the closest thing hydrospatial science has to shared infrastructure, and the annual grid release is the moment to check whether the Indian Ocean's blind spots are actually closing, not just the global average.

The GEBCO_2026 grid, released in April, brings total coverage to 28.7% of the ocean floor, roughly 104 million square kilometres, more than two-thirds of Earth's land surface, after nearly 5 million square kilometres were added in a single year. 220 organisations

have now contributed data, including first-time national submissions from Malaysia, Morocco, Papua New Guinea, and Saudi Arabia. The Seabed 2030 Symposium runs 8 to 9 October in Cartagena, Colombia, worth calendaring now.

seabed2030.org – [Global Seabed Mapping Milestone](#)

07 / PULL QUOTE

"10.01% of the ocean is now officially designated within protected and conserved areas."

That number is the benchmark Francesca will get asked about at every conference this year, and it's leverage as much as milestone. Seychelles pioneered blue-bond-financed MPA expansion back in 2018, protecting 17 million hectares. The rest of the world is only now catching up to the model it built.

IUCN confirms roughly 5 million square kilometres of ocean, an area bigger than the EU, were protected in the past two years alone, with major new designations in Indonesia, Thailand, and Ghana's first-ever MPA. BBNJ's entry into force in January opens

the door to nominating protected areas beyond national jurisdiction for the first time, the next lever on this same trajectory.

[iucn.org](https://www.iucn.org) – World Reaches Milestone for Nature

STORY 08

Mombasa's \$6.4 billion, line by line

This is the funding and diplomatic weather report for the entire blue economy sector Francesca operates in, and it rewards a close read of who committed to what.

The 11th Our Ocean Conference closed in Mombasa on 18 June with US\$6.4 billion pledged across 320 separate commitments from more than 5,000 delegates.

Three outcomes carry weight beyond the venue: a coral reef protection coalition that grew to 20 countries, with Kenya, Comoros, the Dominican Republic, the UK, and Mexico newly signed; the Mombasa Declaration on fisheries transparency, adopted by 16 countries to fight illegal, unreported, and unregulated fishing; and an expanding moratorium on deep-sea mining.

Two new marine protected areas were also announced: 337,000 square kilometres around Chile's Juan Fernández Islands, and the 287,000 square kilometre Azores Marine Park, now the largest protected area network in the North Atlantic. Kenya alone announced 42 commitments worth US\$1 billion as host.

oceanpanel.org – [11th Our Ocean Conference Outcomes](#)

09

Modi came to Victoria with nineteen outcomes

This is happening in Francesca's own capital, in her own sector, while the multilateral processes elsewhere in this edition move at treaty pace. A state visit produces bilateral outcomes in days that BBNJ has spent three years negotiating.

Narendra Modi's state visit to Seychelles, 27 to 29 June, produced nineteen bilateral outcomes spanning development finance, digital payments, maritime cooperation, agriculture, and institutional capacity-building, under the MAHASAGAR vision for regional security and growth. It builds on Seychelles' 2018 status as issuer of the world's first sovereign blue bond, and on February's Mumbai roundtable marking 50 years of India-Seychelles diplomatic ties.

[theweek.in – India-Seychelles Blue Economy Roundtable](#)

⚡ CLOSES 31 AUGUST, 23:59 UTC

STORY 10

Twenty-nine days to put HARMONiSE on the record

This is the direct route to formal Ocean Decade endorsement Francesca has been circling for HARMONiSE and the Ocean Mapping Hub. A recognised Decade Action carries real bureaucratic weight in funding conversations and partnership requests, well beyond what the name alone suggests.

IOC-UNESCO's Call for Decade Actions No. 11/2026 is open until 31 August 2026, addressing priority needs identified in the Barcelona Statement. It covers new Ocean Decade Projects and contributions that strengthen existing Decade Actions and coordination structures. Submissions go through oceansdecade.org, with questions to oceansdecade@unesco.org.

oceansdecade.org – Call for Decade Actions No. 11/2026

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